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WITH VINOBA

Donald G. Groom

SARVA SEVA SANGH PRAKASHAN

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(A DIARY)

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INTRODUCTION

A Diary may not be one of the easiest things to read in booklet form, but it is one of the easiest things to write. My reasons for preparing this one for publication are :

- (a) it is short,
- (b) it may give a feel of Vinobaji's pilgrimage to those who have never had the privilege of walking with him. It will inevitably convey some of the message which Vinobaji wishes to convey, and as it is written in English the message may reach people who would not normally receive it. I have in mind people who live in cities as well as enquirers in and from other countries.

There is no attempt to present a complete idea of Vinobaji's message, but it will be seen that within a period of about a month Vinobaji conveys to the people an almost complete idea of his purpose. The presentation of a Diary with the more personal comments which inevitably get included if one is honestly recording one's daily experiences, thoughts and reactions, may even give a better picture of Vinoba : the man : than if I sat down to write about him.

Quite naturally when one anticipates a meeting with Vinobaji one has a number of questions in mind to place

before him. From previous experience I knew that unless I wrote them down beforehand they would not naturally occur to me at the time, so I wrote them down. Also from past experience I knew that most of my questions would get answered before even I asked them. As it was, it will be seen that I was able to ask a few formally, but the answers to all came. The questions were these :

1. What is your message for friends of *Bhoodan* in England ?
2. What is the reason for *Agnyatwas* : not planning more than a few days ahead ?
3. Could not the difficulties which arose in the *Padyatra* be overcome in some way which will still permit it to be the centre of inspiration for the whole movement ?
4. Is there not an indication that the emphasis of the movement is becoming more philosophical—what have we learnt about non-violent techniques, rather than on the front-line attack on poverty and inequalities ?
5. Should not a definite programme of action go alongside *Sarvodaya Paatra* work—i. e. land distribution ?
6. Workers need practical guidance on programmes of work, should not the Akhil Bharat Sarva Seva Sangh be a more effective instrument for this ?

7. In the organization of the Sarva Seva Sangh should there not be provision for permanent travelling secretaries who will keep in touch with and develop the deeper fellowship of the Loksevakas ?
8. The movement seems to be losing the initiative it once had. It created the environment within which decisions were made in the same way as the climate of Gandhiji's thought and action still determines decisions in certain spheres. How can we regain that position ? Decisions of Governments and individuals in their own particular spheres must still feel the pressure of the poor and of the principles of human dignity. For this is there not nothing better than a revival of *Padyatras* in every district in the country for redistribution of land, setting up of village planning procedures, institution of *Sarvodaya Paatra* etc. ?
9. What is to be our conclusion about *Gramdan* ? Has not the vesting of ownership in the village community to be an expression of *positive* ownership by the community, rather than an individual act of dispossession or registration in a co-operative society ? The question of ownership in the latter is not clearly understood.
10. *Gramdan* should begin with the decision of the whole village to take full responsibility for

everyone. Is this not the equivalent of the present practice in *Bhoodan* for the donor to establish the receiver on the land first before the gift is announced ?

11. I have come back to India convinced that your insight was correct that the same spirit operating in India through Gandhiji and yourself, is operating through individuals and groups in the West. But there is need for someone to bring out the latent spirit there on a wide basis, and all look to you for this. Could you bear this in mind on this pilgrimage ?
 12. Whilst the Sarva Seva Sangh statement on China may be in accord with your ideas in spirit, do you think that the sentence giving moral support for the use of conventional weapons is less than what is expected from a body which has to give a lead on moral principle to those who wish to put non-violence into practice under all circumstances ?
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I

When I was in Delhi I went to Rajghat to find out where Vinobaji would be on Christmas Day. I arrived outside of the offices of the Gandhi Memorial Fund, saw a person walking by the road who looked as though he was a Gandhian worker and stopped him to ask where the *Bhoodan* offices were. To my surprise he said that there wasn't an office, so I told him what I was after. He was just the man in a million. It was as if he had been sent there just to do this service for me. He told me all the details down to the name of the person who would be host to Vinobaji on that day.

II

December 24th.

I am nearer to Vinobaji now, perhaps only 40 miles away. It is Bhatinda Railway Station. Still there is one more train to catch. I spent the whole of yesterday getting here from Delhi and I slept in the waiting room where I now write. A new beginning will be made tomorrow—Christmas Day, 1959, where it will lead to I have no idea. Much depends on what Vinoba says.

I have just spoken to a Sikh who shares this waiting room. He said that Vinoba gets no response from people with good lands in the Punjab, yet his influence is good. Agriculture in the Punjab, he said, is very profitable—he himself having two tractors. The Government is helpful to us, too, he said.

All day yesterday I was looking at the country and the people as we passed in that slow train and I saw the same desperate poverty that I see everywhere. Men, women and children in their masses seemed to be just alive, and the land itself seemed to be shouting a challenge—“You try to get anything out of me if you can !” It was dry, barren and colourless. My constant comment was that the villages look like those in the Middle East, not India—they are groups of flat-roofed, square, mud

coloured houses hardly distinguishable from the sandy soil around them.

S a n g a r i a

It is still Christmas Eve and I have completed the journey of 40 miles from Bhatinda in a metre gauge train in $2\frac{1}{2}$ hours. The border between the Punjab and Rajasthan is but a few hundred yards away.

When I was getting worried as to whether I had come to the right place, the young man by my side in the railway carriage said, 'are you going to Vinobaji, he is in my village today.' What a reassurance that was ! Then as the train stopped I handed my luggage to a man and then a smart young man came up to me and asked me whether I had come to meet Vinoba. I said 'yes', and asked 'where he would be staying ?' 'Come along with me', he said, 'he will be staying in our school, I am one of the teachers'.

III

December 25th.

The morning was bitterly cold. It was difficult to crawl from the sleeping bag at 5 a.m. to go and meet Vinobaji, but this was what I had looked forward to for so long and I was excited to see him again.

With the white shawl around my shoulder I set off with two others in the star-lit morning. By 6.30 we could see the three lamps of the Vinoba party quite clearly, then within a hundred yards in the quiet of the morning Vinoba's voice came clearly to our ears. The clear firm tone thrilled me again. I came up to him and he shouted *Jai Jagat* in greeting—no more than that at first because he was in deep conversation with some one about education. Vinoba was being very severe and I heard him say that he felt critical of every aspect of the educational system in the country. The moment came to go by his side and I stayed until we reached our destination. He said how specially pleased he was that I had come on Christmas Day. Then he said how grateful he was for Iona Cross which Janaki and I had sent him from Iona. It thrilled him when he received it he said. When I explained the significance of Iona, he said, "then when I come to England I must come to Iona first, is that so?"

Vinoba was in good health and spirits, walked briskly and spoke firmly.

During the day Vinoba spoke three times. As usual he had morning recitation at 10.30 and he extended this to include a Christmas Service. I read from the New Testament and sang two carols and Vinobaji read from the *Quran*, *Dhammapad* and *Guru Nanak's 'Japji'*. He then spoke for about 20 minutes taking peace as the subject of the Christmas message, usually linking the names of Jesus and Buddha. He repeated his hope that either England or India would pioneer a new path in the world by unilateral disarmament. He said that people often ask him which language will become the universal language and he said that it would be the language of the country which pioneers the new path of non-violence.

In the afternoon at 2.30 Vinobaji holds a class with all those who are walking with him and an attendance register is kept. This time he unburdened himself expressing his feeling that the movement had become very luke-warm wherever he looked. People have criticised him, he said, for starting new aspects of the movement before the old ones were completed—but, he said that he sees no one taking up any of the aspects fully. He is willing to go and stay in any district where real work is going on, but no district comes up to his expectation or standard, which is that there be a number of workers maintained by the local people through *Sarvodaya Paatra*. The thought has come to him that he should ask 500 *Shanti Seviks* to go and settle in one area and really demonstrate non-violent strength.

In that area there would be no need for the police and no one would go to court to settle dispute.

At the evening prayer meeting there was a large crowd present—a very good spirited crowd which listened carefully to what Vinoba had to say and observed the silence at the end very faithfully. It was a Christmas message—but there was no philosophising, he was hard and critical :—“For the first time in history India and China have become conscious of their common border. No longer could it be thought that the Himalayas are a bulwark. India now had to learn how to build up good neighbour relationships with China, not just for the present but for a thousand years to come. It was unthinkable that India and China should go to war. Both would suffer inestimable losses. The shouting that ‘we are behind Nehru’ is of no use, we have to be in advance of him. We can do this when the people in the villages build up their own non-violent strength through self-sufficiency and self-government, then say to Nehru you don’t need to worry about us. This demands a unity which we have not at present, but the true response to the challenge of the present border dispute should be immediate steps to overcome all the divisions and strife that absorb the energies of the people at present.”

December 26th.

A person from Yugoslavia came today to spend a month teaching Esperanto to Vinobaji. He is an inter-

esting person, having lived in S. America for many years, explored amongst aboriginal tribes, climbed 23,000 ft. and has written about ten books.

During the meeting this afternoon Vinobaji dwelt on the need for a good press for *Sarvodaya*. Whereas he wants utter simplicity for the *Padyatra* he wants the publications so well done that they compete with those in England and America.

“During the past decade *Sarvodaya* has built for itself a platform. People are interested to hear about *Sarvodaya* they come in their crowds daily. The leaders of the people give open recognition to the virtues of *Sarvodaya*. But so far we have not built up a Press. Through the Press news of *Sarvodaya* work and thought should be reaching every home in the country and the far corners of the world. It is up to capable journalists and the *Sarvodaya* Movement to take up this at once.”

In the early morning at 4.30 we set out as usual for a three hour walk. There were but a few walking alongside Vinoba. The head of the institution, *Swamy Keshavanand* was with us, but he was keeping in the rear. When Vinoba started to speak, it was obvious that he was feeling dissatisfied. He had entered Rajasthan for the second or third time and he was looking for some indication of progress of the work, but none was forthcoming. He had been called to the institution but there was no indication of anything but a warm hospitality. What

he had seen at the School Museum had rather sickened him. Few realise what a revolutionary *Baba* is. He hit hard at the *Swamy* whom he thought was caught in the mesh of an institution when he ought to be free to do creative work in society. The *Swamy* remained at the back obviously feeling a bit sore, but within half an hour he was by Vinobaji's side asking that he might talk to him. The next hour saw a wonderful exhibition of the way in which Vinobaji can bring out the best in people. In spite of absolutely straight talk the *Swamiji* was ready in the end to give up his seat in Parliament, hand over the institution to others and carry out Vinoba's programme. I saw Vinoba as rather a harsh person, but because he has no personal enmity and only has the best interests of the people at heart, he can win through and win affection.

That evening prayer meeting also annoyed *Baba*. He saw the mike and groups of people scattered over the field. He reached the platform, asked people to come nearer in one group and then said that he has made a firm decision not to use the mike again. He then went on to criticise the indiscipline of the people and not only that he snapped at those who thought they had bought his favour by contributing a few rupees in *Sampattidan*. "Don't people realise that I am walking through the country for eight years to spread a revolutionary thought," he said.

Not only then but at other times Vinoba remarked that, "non-violence demands greater discipline than violence".

VI

December 29th.

Hanumangarh (Rajasthan)

This is a town of 15,000 population which is overshadowed by a huge fortress. The municipal chairman seems to have every thing in hand for our reception. Having arrived at about 7 a.m. before sunrise *Baba* was prepared to have a meeting with those who came to welcome him and it went on for about an hour. A hundred people sat, partly covered by their blankets, and listened with a sense of awe to what *Baba* was saying. He gave them a simple address thanking them for taking the trouble to welcome him and lending on to give a very moving appeal based on and with reference to the message of Jesus to the rich young ruler. Here everyone has a camel and a few are very rich so the story of it being easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle than a rich man to enter the Kingdom of God had a very direct significance. He said that he had been walking through the country for nine years asking for a sixth—of land, wealth and time. This demand was still there, he added, but what I have really come for is for men, for the response of the hearts of people who will give their lives for this work.

This is the 3rd morning that I have walked with Vinoba this time. The group with him is quite small—

no more than ten in number usually. There are about ten others who go in the vehicles, the drivers, sellers of literature etc. Being a small group it is more informal and there is more opportunity of talking with Vinoba. Each morning I have had the opportunity of quite a long talks. The other morning I raised the question of the border problem with China, saying that some on behalf of the *Shanti Sena* should be active in solving the problem. This brought out the suggestion from Vinoba which may have long-term significance. In effect, he said that first we must demonstrate in this country the power of non-violence and for this, he said, I have been considering for some time the idea of a Stateless Society in this country comprised of from 1 to 10 lakhs people, in which the experiment could be carried out. Taxes could be paid to the Central Government, but there would be no other allegiance to central authority—there would be no police, no army and no administration from the centre. The Peace Army volunteers would be there, otherwise it would be a self-sufficient, self-governing community. Foreign aid would only be welcome from individuals who fully believed in the purpose of the Stateless Society. During the last three days Vinoba has made several references to this.

Yesterday morning I let go on all sorts of subjects. But let me say what Vinoba said about the British friends of *Bhoodan*. "I neither encourage nor discourage them !"

He was meaning in relation to the economic help they were proposing.

First of all I spoke about Kashmir. Vinoba said that during his walk there he discovered that the people would welcome a joint administration between India and Pakistan. I said, then why don't you Vinoba call Ayubkhan and Nehruji to join you in discussions to come to a settlement of the issue? I said that I did not think that his sense of the weakness of the *Shanti Sena* should prevent him from taking this step. Vinoba replied, "I don't feel at all weak for such a task." I then pressed further and said that the time was come when he should act from the plans of *Jai Jagat* and that he should have people available who could be sent to any area of conflict in the world including China. Vinoba left it at that, thought he did not rule out the possibility. Other matters came up but they did not bring forth any special comment from Vinoba, though I felt that his reaction to my question on *Gramdan* was sympathetic.

On the walk today we opened up a conversation which covered worship and prayer.

The question of common worship has arisen at the Sadhana Kendra where people of different religious backgrounds will be living a life of spiritual discipline and common action for *Sarvodaya*. The workers at the Kendra had suggested that each should be free to follow his own path. This was not what Vinoba wanted. In answer

to my question he said that there were several approaches to common worship and prayer. The path which Gandhiji chose trying to include all religions was one, but Vinoba felt that it led to many difficulties. The path of synthesis was another in which a worship form is adopted taking in the essence of all religions. The other was a path which excluded all outward expressions of worship—the acceptance of silence, which I am using more and more. The last path was that which spontaneously arose out of the common life and fellowship of people of different religious backgrounds. Vinobaji said that he wanted more experiment on the lines of the last named which would help towards the development of *Manav Dharma*—a rule of life for mankind.

I recorded the conversation on Esperanto between *Baba* and Tibor Sekllj from Yugoslavia. It was very good—*Baba* still insisting that if England pioneered the path of peace through unilateral disarmament then there would be no reason why English should not become the international language :

—“Our society has no discipline, that is why such a huge nation has no inner strength. It was because of this that a few British soldiers and officers could rule the country.

Some gifts were announced just now. I did not come here for such gifts, I came to spread a new revolutionary thought. They whose names were announced will

think that they have obtained a place in heaven. I do not like this announcing in public. He whose name is lost in the name of God is worth remembering. It is a fact that in the history and culture of India the names that are remembered by the people are not the kings, army leaders etc. but the sages, saints and names of God.

India has only a future hope if it follows the line of non-violent strength, it has none in following the path of Russia and America.

In our ancient tradition there is a call to those who reach a certain age to become servants of the people, *Vanaprasthas*, but now people say that there is no one available for the service of the villages.

Each has some gift, some ability which he can use for the good of society. It is to stir up the people in this direction that I am walking”.

December 26th.

—“Up to now there has been very little relationship with China—a few people have gone there and a few have come from there to India.

In this age of science China and India must come together. All nations must lose their narrow view and think in terms of membership of a world family. What can we do to build this sense of world citizenship?

The step for us is to make one area in India comprising about one lakh of people a Non-state area—there will be

no police, no law courts and no central administration, and the affairs will be carried on on the basis of unanimity.

If we can have one example of that kind it will only be an indication of the conception I have for the whole society. I want a society free from Governmental law and domination.

If this were done it would be a revolutionary work whereas most of what is done now is relief work which has been carried on for ages.

Saint Gyandev and others have dreamed of such a society as I want. It must be an educated one and it should keep aware of all that goes on in the world. It should act as a leaven in the world.

People have proclaimed such ideals before but they have been treated as counsels of perfection and they have been thought of as good for the perfect future or for individual salvation or for the after life.

How long have we to continue in this way ?”

December 27th.

—“I am giving some time these days to the study of Esperanto. This is a remarkable creation which has the object of creating world brotherhood. What a great idea it was when it came to someone that to bring people together it was necessary to have one language. Dr. L. L. Zamenhof created such a language which has been learnt by five million people so far. Some parents must

have learnt it and it will soon become a mother tongue for their children.

The possibility of the world becoming one has been demonstrated by science, and it is right, but what a remarkable thing to make a language for this purpose. It has its world conferences already. There are 2,500 million people in the world and China and India account for 1,000 million of these. There cannot be less than a thousand languages in all. People have taken the courage to add one more language to these which, if not today, then tomorrow the literate people of the world will learn along with their mother tongue. I consider the person to whom this vision came a *Scint* or a *Rishi*. It is a tremendous work, a new language, new rules, new grammar, new literature, and after I told an Australian that I would learn if a Yugoslavian has been sent to teach me. He is teaching me and telling of the greatness of the language.

Where is Australia? Where is Yugoslavia? Where is India? But he thought that a person wants to learn Esperanto, is learning and will continue to learn, and so he came. What personal benefit is there in this to him?

To learn English would serve the same purpose perhaps. Every one could become familiar with the English language but my teacher says, when will the Chinese and Russians agree to learn English? From this point of view Esperanto is the right language, he thinks. If English could spread why not Esperanto? With such faith in this language he talks to me.

The thought behind Esperanto I find gives me joy and inspiration. To give the world one language and through it forge world unity is as if it were the task of Jesus.”

December 31st.

We are still in Rajasthan in a real backwater of the world. On the walk this morning *Baba* decided that we should sit for half an hour for meditation. It was cold and rather uncomfortable for me but we were given a treat by Vinoba as he sang several devotional songs in Marathi. He also spoke about the Sarva Seva Sangh resolution. He said that it was a mistake to speak in terms of the weakness of the *Shanti Sena* in reference to the border conflict with China. The *Shanti Sena* was never expected to be used in dealing with conflict between nations which acknowledge the necessity of the use of arms. If it were even allowed to be used under such circumstances it would only be to serve the interests of the nation not non-violence. What the *Shanti Sena* has to do is to build up strength within the nation so that the military and arms might be dispensed with. In this task the *Shanti Sena* is weak but it has to build up its strength through the development of self-sufficient, self-governing communities. There was no question of supporting the Government in persuing its programme of dealing with the situation, but he did want to say that he found in Nehru's speeches and action the highest expression of non-violent thought under the circumstances.

The main speech which Vinoba gave at Hanumangarh hinged on two new phrases which he coined—the *Anna plan* for the 5 year plan, and *Nakad Dharma*. The main theme, as it so often is, was the building of the strength of the people. We were becoming more and more dependent on the Government for every thing, he said, adding several amusing instances. We think that the government has, through its 5 year plans, all the power for good in its hands. Then he worked it out that the expenditure counted to one anna per day per person, so, he said, it is a 'one anna plan' in other words it represented 20 minutes work per day. Place this, he added, beside the 8 hours work per day which power every person has and see where the real power for development lies.

He spoke of *Nakad Dharma*. Most people think in terms of religious action providing for a future benefit in heaven or in a future life. "That is what I call *Udhar Dharma*"—(religion on credit) "what I want is *Nakad* (cash on the spot) religion". In other words he wants the performance of action to reap their immediate reward, or have its immediate effect.

Yesterday's address was a simple and delightful one to uneducated village people—"overcome fear, I have come to act as the 'prohohit' (intermediary) in the marriage between the master and worker, the rich and the poor." he said.

In that village there were 12 big land lords but none came to see Vinoba.

V

January 1st 1960

It was a dark, cold morning at 3.20 a.m. when I woke to the New Year. After the prayers, *Swamiji* and several others wished me a happy New Year, otherwise it was hardly possible to realise that there was any special day. But last evening I went to sit by *Baba* half an hour before the prayer and I had a wonderful treat for the New Year's eve. *Baba* was singing Gyandev songs, which he loves so much, and interpreting them into Hindi. I was the only one present apart from Mahadevi Tai.

Whilst we were sitting for meditation at about 6.45 a.m. *Baba* said a few words to the Rajasthan workers as tomorrow we enter the Punjab. He said that he thought that Ganganagar District in which we were walking was ripe for *Sarvodaya*—it was virgin soil and along with the new canal water the *Sarvodaya* message should reach the people. He wanted two or three workers to concentrate here.

At the class at 2.30 in the after noon Vinoba again spoke about the workers. He said that he wanted one in every district to report to him every day on the activities in the district. The district worker should be in touch with all workers in the area. Then *Baba* went on to give his main message. "There are three main problems to be

overcome in the country: poverty, ignorance and ill-health, but in the solution of these, help will come from private sources and government. But there is one thing that *Sarvodaya* has to do and perhaps alone, to correct wrong moral values.”

January 2nd.

Today we walked along the Railway line to Ellenabad, a distance of seven miles. It is a small business centre lying within the Punjab border. It is said that it is such an out-of-the-way place that no one of importance ever comes here, not even political leaders. So there is a great welcome from the people—but from curious people who only want a glimpse of this great man, Vinoba. The people of the town seem to be so engrossed in their money making that even though they build good houses, they leave the streets in a terribly insanitary condition; filthy water lies through the centre of most of the streets. Several political leaders have come to meet Vinoba and at the rather sumptuous meal there must have been 50 of us present.

We arrived at 7-30 and at about 8-30 *Baba* came to address the gathering which had assembled to welcome him in the school playground. *Baba* was conscious of having entered a new district and as his efforts were now being concentrated in a district, he came forth with a new idea which he wanted trying in this district. It was further developed in the afternoon class. The importance of workers is such that he now wants *Sampattidan* collected

specially for their maintainance, then after a year they should be able to get their maintainance from *Sarvodaya Paatra*. This, he hopes, will give them some security and give them time to build up the *Sarvodaya Paatra* programme. He wants ten workers in Hissar district.

During the walk in the morning I took up a matter which arose from his short message during meditation. He had spoken of the importance of building up a group consciousness amongst the workers in the movement. This, he said, meant acting above the mental level. It meant trust in the good faith of others. It meant giving less importance to one's own point of view and more to what might evolve out of group consciousness, which would mostly be greater than any view of the individual. I spoke of the difficulty of this in India on account of Indian tradition and he agreed, saying that even one song in India can be sung in sixty different ways. He also agreed that India had to learn much about this from the Quakers.

In the afternoon class he referred to this and said that although all workers will not have the capacity for high thinking, they should realise the importance of it even while concentrating on practical programme of work.

Vinoba agreed on the programme for the next four days—we stay one day more in Ellenabad : but it is 4.30 a.m. and six miles for *Baba* even though we return to the same place.

January 3rd.

I walked with *Baba* this morning although the prospect of an extra hour or two in my sleeping bag was attractive. After an hour we stopped for meditation. A rug was spread over the grain stumps in a field and we sat round *Vinoba*. It was dark and cold. *Vinoba* began by saying the usual Sanskrit Slokas and after 10 minutes silence closed with *Om Shanti, Shanti, Shanti*. Then he spoke very quietly for about 15 minutes sharing his deeper thoughts, as Jesus had done, with his closest associates. He immediately started, to my surprise, talking about the Quakers, the work that they do in the world, the important decisions they have made and said that the basis of their life is communion in silence and unanimous decisions. This is definitely Indian, he said, and then went on to describe the old *Panchayat* system. "It is important that we use this way of silence and making decisions unanimously in small groups and in our villages and institutions", he added.

During the walk back *Baba* spoke most of the time with a local political leader, and I was encouraged by every thing he said. The main point that was made was that the greatest strength and security would come to India in her relationships with Pakistan and China when India decided to disarm completely. The other path would lead to poverty and involvement in the power blocks.

The afternoon class was quite important too. *Baba* began by saying that *Kruschev* had suggested agreement

on complete disarmament in the world, but had said that if there was no agreement the U.S.S.R. would disarm and maintain rocket bases on the frontier. It was a great step forward, *Baba* said, but it showed that *Kruschev* still had faith in defense by armaments. What was needed, he added, was that nations should defend on trust and goodwill for their defense and offer non-violent, non-co-operation with evil. The energies of the nations should be directed to constructive activities. The *Upanishads* have written about Grow More Food. *Baba* said that he hoped that one day there will be no price on food—it will be as free as air.

January 4th.

The departure was rather more eventful today. First we stopped at a house for *Baba* to declare open a Bookshop, and then we stopped at the site of the building which will be used for a Bookshop ultimately, and *Baba* placed a brick as its corner stone. After five miles we stopped at another village. The people were assembled peacefully so *Baba* spoke for five minutes. Later we had our usual meditation and *Vinoba* commented on a section of *Gyandev's* poetry in relation to *Sadhana*—the path mentioned being: purity of mind, mental development and awakening. *Baba* is very frequently referring to *Gyandev*, but it is to be expected because he spends many spare moments each day reciting from his works. The other quotations made often come from the Bible—he is very impressed with *Jesus' remark* “settle with thine adversaries quickly.”

Walking round these villages one is still reminded of the near East or Morocco. There are huge, tall, thick walls within which the family has its living quarters and keeps all the animals : cows, bullocks, goats and camels. The whole design, building and decoration of the houses is very pleasing and shows culture. Each family has a separate place for heating milk until it is a concentrate. One looks down a street and sees nothing but high mud faced walls. This afternoon it was lovely seeing a young camel three days old. The sight of the women is extraordinary—all seem to have their faces covered and having a jewel on top of the head or plaited hair, they look rather like walking ghosts or the Ku Klux Klan. I feel annoyed because they can see us whilst we cannot see them.

After walking round the village Mr. Tibor and I were asked to sit in the courtyard of the head-man, a tall, heavy built Jat—and soon 30 or 40 people sat around. By the end of a half hour we had given our life histories, given our opinions on India (always asked) and talked about Vinoba.

During the past ten days I have been with *Baba* this time, I have seen one distinct change. He gives more and more place to silence. In the morning and evening prayers, before and after workers' meetings, at meditations as well as at the public meetings, there is always a period of silence.

—“Who has the right over my time : It is forty years since I gave my service to the people and I have joined

no party nor have I followed the normal worldly life. But I have love and respect for all who have entered normal life and have taken responsibility for families. If such people give some time midst a busy life for devotion it is much more valuable. So those who give some time to my work inspite of heavy responsibilities, have my full respect. As for me, I am as free as a child. A child is one who has the deepest sleep. I am like that. I have no worries. I am absolutely at your disposal.

If I get much *Sampattidan* and no one's mind and heart, I will consider it valueless. I want to share what knowledge and insight I have with people and then pass on. I am really looking for the fire in the hearts of people as I go along."

VI

January 5th.

It was a ten mile walk this morning and by the time we reached the village I was tired. We have been given a room in the hospital—a small affair—and we are recorded as suffering from Vinobaitis ! There is a constant effort to provide Tibor and me with some quiet and comfort.

We stopped after four miles at a village. There was a roaring bonfire which we could see from a distance. The village people were sitting near it. To one side there was a table with teapot and cups neatly arrayed. A worker was addressing the people, keeping them quiet and interested, and when Vinoba arrived all was silent except the noise of the flaming fire. Vinoba must have taken a quick glimpse around and his eyes fell on the tea cups. This set fire to him. "We will not touch any of the milk you are offering us. We are not walking to be fed, we have come for land for the poor and the landless." So he spoke with fire in his words. I felt bad about it because I am sure that the intention of the village people was to express in their way a loving welcome. Vinoba modified his tone a bit but he must have hurt. But we passed on never to return.

During the last hour of the walk Mr. Tibor and I had a long discussion with Vinoba in English, though we did most of the talking.

The talk was opened on the question of world population, Vinoba agreeing with Tibor that there was not really a problem of population in world—science could make it possible for ten times the population to be fed. Tibor suggested that what was needed was an authority which would enable transfer of population to take place—land gifts between nations. To this Vinoba said : “It would be the final outcome of the *Bhoodan Yanga*.” “What was needed in the world is goodwill between the nations,” he added.

At this I suggested that there was a tremendous fund of goodwill in the world—I was sure of it in England—but what was required were channels of expression. Such channels, I suggested, had been opened up in India by Vinoba. His comment was that he wished that the money now spent on armaments would be spent on building up bond of love and goodwill between nations.

I raised the question of gifts because this was one channel open to a prosperous nation to show goodwill towards another, but so often a gift had a demoralising effect. He agreed and said that he wanted the people to learn self-help and dependence on their own resources. He did not expand on the subject, he rather indicated that the solution lay in a wider acceptance of the conception that every thing belongs to the lord and the rejection of private ownership.

The evening meeting was held as usual. There were many who came with reverence and respect, an exception-

ally large group being women with faces covered. At the end Vinoba made special reference to them and said that although they may not have understood all that he had said they knew that he had come to spread the kingdom of love. After the meeting was over I was standing behind the platform. *Baba* left and then several women came running to pick up the sand which had been touched by *Baba's* feet. What a prize they had gained but I cannot imagine what they will do with it. True, to them *Baba* is an incarnation of the God whom they worship and they would expect to get, and perhaps get, great blessing from the sand this Saint touched.

January 6th.

Another ten miles in the sand today. It was cloudy—so not so cold at night and not so warm at dawn. The sky was beautiful as the sun rose and I would have filmed it if I had not been talking to Vinoba at the time. He asked me a lot about education in England, and it seemed to impress him because on arrival he spoke to the gathering about the mid day dinners for children in English schools “food before study is right”, he said.

I put the question about *Gramdan* to him—why not concentrate on the constructive approach, village planning, co-operative life, local government etc. and let the giving up of private ownership on land come later : His reply was thus “In India we have to concentrate on the giving up of private ownership, there is no vacuum in

✓ the constructive field because government through community projects is tackling it."

During class today *Baba* referred to a story given by *Shri Ramakrishna*. The religious aspirant is like butter which when boiled (active) makes a lot of noise letting off the alien element, water, then the final *ghee* makes no noise at all—completely peaceful and calm (words are no longer useful). Then when a student or disciple comes he is like a *puri* being placed in the hot *ghee*, it splutters and makes a noise again (begins to talk and use words) but it is not the *ghee* that makes the noise it is caused by the *puri*, the *ghee* remains within itself calm and silent.

In public *Vinoba* continues to place his emphasis on two things—the building up of the family spirit in the village where problems are solved in the spirit of love and sharing; and the plea for a response for part-time or full-time service for the good of the whole community. This was his emphasis today. Towards the end of his talk he repeated what I have heard him say before—that the Indian scriptures say that no one should die in his home. He made a direct appeal to individuals in his audience for all who are over forty five to devote their lives to the service of the community.

January 7th.

We had very important discussions today as we walked. They were with *Tibor Sekelj* and the local M.L.A. I wish I could have recorded every thing that *Vinoba* said. The

discussion with Tibor began raising the question of the international language. Tibor suggested that Esperanto could be the language accepted even under *Baba's* terms, for there were five million Esperantists who accepted the way of peace and tried to achieve peace and understanding by non-violent means. But *Baba* said that that was different. There are others such as the Quakers and pacifists who work for peace. What is wanted is that Esperantists, Quakers, Pacifists etc. should try to convince one nation to accept the way of unilateral disarmament. Tibor said that it would be better to get the whole world to accept disarmament through Esperanto. "This was the 'All or Nothing' policy of Ike and Krushchev," retorted Vinoba. Tibor suggested that unilateral action would expose frontiers of nations and put them at the mercy of anyone : and quick came the reply that frontiers should be open to all. People should be welcomed. If they want land and it is available they should be given land, if it is not available they should be asked to go where there is spare land. "We should believe in the mercy of others," he said. "If we love only those who love us what have we done ? Nothing !"

The conversation with the M.L.A. was very extensive. It began because the M.L.A. was favourable to the idea that a certain part of the Punjab be transferred to Rajasthan. Vinoba was against this. "Even if there are difficulties we must learn to overcome them." "The time is rapidly

coming", Vinoba said, "when the whole idea of provincial boundaries will be out of date." The modern age of science and technology demands the conception of the *one world*, and the primary unit will be the village or small unit—gradually all intermediaries between that and the world authority which will be for advice and service will be broken down. What we have to do is to build up the village units in India as self-sufficient, self-governing units. The self-sufficiency should be in basic needs of food, clothing and shelter; the self-governing units may be a number of villages. But in order that this idea may be accepted the people have to come to the position where they want to abandon all party politics and remove the authority of centralised government. There should be no concentration of power at the centre anywhere—the fact that Ike, Krushchev and a few others can lead the world to a catastrophe is frightful. *Baba* referred to J.P's., recent proposals and said that they would be approved and complimented but considered utopian and impracticable. The only basis for their acceptance would be the sense of rejection of the party system and the idea of concentration of power.

January 8th.

We lost the way in the dark this morning. It was Vinoba who took things in hand and, guided by the stars, he led us to the road we should have taken. He talked much about Venus and Jupiter afterwards. Later I came

beside him and we had a very deep discussion which is impossible to repeat here. I raised the question of *Gramdan* again and made the suggestion that when people take the step of renouncing ownership over the land, even though no reconstruction work is carried on there, there must be a minimum act symbolising the fact of common ownership. I suggested that this might be that from the date of the decision no individual payment of tax should be made : it should be made by the village assembly. It might even be good for such a village to set aside at once and cultivate in common a piece of land from the income of which the tax would be paid. Vinoba agreed with this and with the emphasis that it is the movement; responsibility to secure the renunciation of ownership and not to carry on development work. He said that in the Punjab he was not emphasising *Gramdan* but was primarily trying to obtain workers, *Sampattidan* and *Sarvodaya Paatra* for their maintenance, and trying to get *Sarvodaya* literature stalls opened.

During the later discussion Vinoba said : "It is not a question of faith that people continue to live after death, it is a matter of experience, I know that Gandhiji is with us still." Later he said after a few moments of deep reflection, much moved, "Gandhiji said to me that just as the sun setting does not mean that the sun ceases to exist, so I know that when I pass on I shall continue to work."

Towards the end I asked whether the word *Sarvodaya* was comprehensive enough to encompass all that he was

working for in the personal, social, economic, educational and religious fields, and he said that it was, adding—"it is a word that must come into world usage as it cannot be translated." Then Tibor announced—"I will see that it is included in Esperanto and there was a chuckle.

—"My experience has been very good in the small villages—the local people in this village have done a lot.. but now I want workers. They have promised to do something about this too. There is a tremendous respect and reverence amongst the people ; it is the strength of their devotion that works. The highest expression of devotion will be when all accept the unity of the village and each serve the other. There must be no other motive in this, it must be service for service sake. There is no value in going to see *Yogis* in mountains. Carry out your devotion in the village and serve the people in their need. Such workers we want; unattached, they will serve in the full spirit of love, they will find fulfilment in this. If you give a thirsty man drink and expect something in return there will be no value in the act for you; but doing it without expectation of return will purify your life. People have little faith now because they see so few who serve without ulterior motive."

VII

January, 9th

The walk this morning was another tiring one, though no tiredness was shown by Vinoba. It was at least 10 miles on a sandy road and Vinoba spoke several times. First at 6.15 he spoke for about 10 minutes to the crowd sitting around a fire and he ended by reciting a very fine Sanskrit prayer to *Agni*. Then at 6.45 after the meditation he spoke for 15 minutes on the banks of a canal and finally on arrival he gave 15 minutes—all inspiring messages. From 7 until 9 a.m. when we arrived he was talking with someone or teaching Marathi. With all he showed no fatigue and said that he was feeling in perfect health. By 10.30 a.m. he was singing the Vishnu Sahasranama at the top of his voice with great gusts, at 11 he was teaching Sanskrit to three girls and then at 11.30 came the Esperanto class with us. Such is the man Vinoba.

During the morning discussions—the walking university, *Baba* gave a detailed description of the new political order for India. It begins with the village. There the village council will be elected unanimously by the village assembly—"God speaks through the fire," will be its authority. The District assembly will be comprised of the members of the village councils and it will elect unanimously a District Council. The members of the

District Council will form the State Assembly and it will elect in the same way the State Council and so on to the National Government.

January 10th.

Seven miles walk along the railway line brought us to the village of Bhattu—a commercial centre. After the meditation on the way Vinoba spoke about the first two *Slokas* of the Isawasya Upanishad. Of these lines Gandhiji once said, “If all the literature of Hinduism were destroyed and these lines remained, there would be a sound basis in them for the Hindu religion.” Vinoba said that he had liked this Upanishad since his childhood. He had written a commentary on it and after returning from jail he used it alone for his morning prayer instead of the prayers used by Gandhiji. Since the beginning of the *Bhoodan* Movement it has been used by workers all over the country.

Vinoba's address to the crowd that welcomed him this morning was couched in very strong terms. It was very critical of the village conditions. He, more or less, said that when China is threatening on the 2500 miles frontier, when are Indian villages going to wake up and bring about true *Gram Swarajya*? The village people are ignorant, he said, and one day when he was speaking to a woman recently he found that she did not even know that Gandhiji was dead. He said that what he would like to do is to make sure that news reached every corner

of India within seven days. To do this he wants a worker for every seven villages so that each village will be visited by him every seven days.

January 11th.

We were very late and tired arriving at Fatehabad today after twelve miles walk. It is not an attractive town but the Dharmshala in which we are staying is comfortable and clean. *Baba* was conscious of there being many refugees from Pakistan present, so he spoke accordingly. Members of the Sarva Seva Sangh have come to talk with Vinoba, so I mostly listen in. I am still worried by the way in which decisions are made and the way in which all seem undecided or hesitant until Vinoba's word is obtained.

There was no Esperanto class today. There is a Sanskrit phrase which *Baba* repeats on such occasions which means that studies are postponed on the arrival of important visitors. The Esperanto class is interesting. Tibor has come all the way from Yugoslavia to teach *Baba* and he has his own teaching methods, but *Baba* from the beginning has taken the initiative and in a sense has been his own teacher; merely using Tibor as a reference book. It is natural because *Baba* has learnt so many languages, has his own methods of doing so, and is not interested in the language as a spoken language so much. It annoys Tibor a bit, but now he is more interested in the publicity value of Vinoba learning Esperanto than getting Vinoba to speak it fluently.

January 12th.

The rain greeted us at the village today and it was most unpleasant. This village is said to be the second most advanced in the Punjab, so I am looking forward to seeing it. During the walk Vinobaji was expressing his disgust at the way the Sarva Seva Sangh had taken up the work in the country—I have never heard him so critical. Once he said : “Admit your quiet.” It is very difficult to understand this situation because all along I am sure that the Sarva Seva Sangh has thought that it was doing things according to the wishes of Vinoba. I am sure that some decisions were made entirely out of respect for Vinoba’s judgement of the right step forward. The ture situation apropos Vinoba and the Sarva Seva Sangh is not clear. Obviously Vinoba has no organisational responsibilities. He likes to keep completely free, so free that he might not say today something which is in line with what he said yesterday. The Sarva Seva Sangh, however, has organisational responsibility but perhaps it has never seen the vision of the non-violent revolution which Vinoba wants clearly enough to make it its own. Therefore, whereas Vinobaji carries on and gains new inspiration from day to day on the basis that the work is being carried on all over the country by the Sarva Seva Sangh, the latter is perplexed by the manifold aspects of the movement and lack of unified direction which they look to Vinobaji for. So the movement wonders where its leadership is and Vinobaji

wonders why no work is being carried on. The answer is in the Sarva Seva Sangh getting a better vision of the Movement as initiated and inspired by Vinoba and making it its own. This will give Vinoba the confidence which will enable him to advance into spheres which are his own. Why should Vinoba look for workers ?

The special features of this village named Bangaon are as follows : There has been a *Panchayat* functioning in the village for twelve years and the Head has been elected unanimously (a good look at him made me feel in my naughtiness that no one dare to elect anyone else), all the roads in the village have been paved with brick with drainage in the centre of the road, there is street lighting and a very good school building. All the development works have been paid for by the *Panchayat* from house tax, income from the renting of a tractor and use of a flour mill and Government grant.

Tibor and I walked round the village and were called to sit with about twenty others in the house of the *Panchayat* Chairman. It was a good occasion. The local M.L.A. was there and the discussion in Hindi covered a wide field. The villagers are evidently politically conscious and keep up with the national and world events, but it was acknowledged that it was what Nehru said which they accepted. When I asked, after Nehru what, they could only think of Jayaprakash Narayan—no other person could claim the heart of the people. I asked about the China question and the reply was staggering—"There is more hatred for

the Chinese now than there ever was for the British!" In regard to Vinoba they said that all village people have the highest reverence for a Saint like Vinoba—but the giving business is quite another matter. They agreed that although few understood what he was talking about, when they went back to their houses they explained that Vinoba wanted them to solve all their problems in the village and live in friendship one with another. That is something.

January 13th.

The rising bell went at 3 a.m. as usual, then the 3.30 bell for morning prayer. At 4.25 exactly another bell goes warning everyone that *Baba* was about to begin the daily walk. The pilot with the lamp is there, and two others carry lamps at his feet. For an hour there is no speaking unless Vinoba, as is frequent, makes some comment on the stars. Soon we came to a village where there was a bonfire and people gathered. Vinoba just recited the Sanskrit prayer to *Agni* and passed along. At another village *Baba* just raised his hands in greeting and moved on. At the third village he stopped and spoke for ten minutes and then finally at the destination he spoke for fifteen minutes. He is now asking people to spin and contribute one hank of yarn before February 12th, Gandhiji's *Shraddha Divas*.

Vinoba was again very critical about the movement. At one time he said : "I am out of time with the way in which

the work is being carried on, but when the reply was made that if you are depressed then it makes us even more so.” Vinoba said: “I am not depressed, if I were my feet would not keep going.”

It is always interesting to study how Vinobaji deals with people. He seems mostly delighted to wipe the floor with every one within the first few minutes. His replies to what seem to be excuses are cutting. His knowledge of people and situations all over the country make it difficult for anyone to put anything over. Then when he has made the person very introspective he speaks in positive terms of new prospects and opens up to him a new vision of his importance. When a practical decision about the future seems to be possible, Vinoba is quiet and meekly says, we will think over it, which means ‘stay with me for some time and then I will let you know what comes to me.’ Then a moment will come when Vinoba will give a clear, inspiring direction. I would really like to examine this technique—I have some doubts about it.

—“Ike, in search for peace, is touring India. He recognises the importance of coming to this country. Krushchev may also come for the second time. The ex-Raja of Sarawak, Antony Brooke is touring the world and is going to China—all in search of peace. Tibor Sekelj from Yugoslavia is here teaching a language of peace-Esperanto, and I am giving an hour a day to learn it. There is a still less important person here, Donaldji,

who learnt Hindi for service and love. From Ike and Kruschev to Tibor and Donald, people are in search of peace.

Now there is a new relationship between China and India being built up. The Himalayas used to divide countries, now they unite people. Camels also bring people together. Mountain, the sky every thing joins men—but men divide amongst themselves. Now is the time when the work of uniting people has to be undertaken. When at first the contact is made there may be some struggle but there is nothing to worry about in that. The contact between India and China has come to stay.

We talk in terms of Nehru looking after the security of the people, so Ike, so Kruschev—they are responsible for millions. It is wrong to place such responsibility in the hands of so few people. We must let Nehru look after relationships with other countries and we must look after our own villages. We will not do evil, we will not run away, nor fight. Through this our leaders will have less weight on their heads and they will be in a stronger position. In the present conditions India imports 100 million tons of grain a year, what would happen if war came ?

—Lots of people from Pakistan are living here and they have suffered very much. Many Muslims left this area too. This was a great tragedy for the country that

took place twelve years ago. I know the condition of the refugees because for nearly two years I used to move amongst them. In the end people become satisfied with their conditions. Sometimes there is happiness, sometimes sorrow and the latter is usually remembered the longest. During the last nine years I have been ill three times—I remember that. I remember the day I did not sleep. So it seems as though there is more sorrow in the world but on the whole joy and sorrow may be equal, though some suffer a lot and others are happy. The Punjab has probably suffered the greatest, but they are so brave they forgot it.

Gandhiji taught us non-violence and the British left without bloodshed, but we collapsed. The fear of insecurity grew amongst the Hindus and Muslims although they used to live in peace and share each others lives. We made such a disgraceful display that we can hardly think of it—now it has been forgotten.

When I knew that there were many refugees I knew that *Bhoodan* would do well here—who can say whose father owned that land ! Now the Maharaja of Patiala has taken to cricket, he is no longer a Raja. No one remembers the thousands of Rajas who have come and gone—only Raja Ram is remembered. Even the viceroy for whose car the whole road was cleared—he has gone. Still people want to know how they can preserve their names in schools by picture on the wall etc. Some people whose pictures are on walls did nothing but kill—who will remem-

ber them, it will be the names of Jesus, Buddha—which will be remembered.

The lesson we have to learn is that no one can be master over the soil, so why have ownership over land, let it belong to the village think of everyone as a member of your family and make provision for everyone.

VIII

January 14th.

We reach a point ten miles from Hissar after $11\frac{1}{2}$ miles walk and rain again gave us a very unpleasant welcome. It was fun running with *Baba*.

I ask myself what did I learn about Vinoba and his ideas during the five hours walk. The first to go beside him was a member of the Bharatiya Jan Sangh party. His comment was that it appeared that Congress was making capital out of the *Bhoodan* Movement and Vinoba, and many so-called *Bhoodan* workers vote Congress. Vinoba did not accept this as a criticism. He wants people of all parties to work for *Bhoodan*, as indeed they are doing. There are very few in the country, he said, who openly oppose the movement. Even though Prof. Ranga is against, other leaders of the Swatantra Party are not. I find my words, he added, being quoted by all parties in their favour—and then with a twinkle said “if they quote correctly I have nothing against it.” Criticism of his outlook in regard to cow protection was mentioned and Vinoba said that he had supported the banning of the killing of cows, but had also said that Acts of Parliament would never save the cow. The Jan Sangh member was defeated in argument, but I felt that *Baba* used ‘brow beating’ methods. He seemed to enjoy squashing his

adversary in argument and, of course, he is very clever at it. I don't think that under these conditions a good argument takes place, and I often feel that more could be said on the other side—though, no doubt, Vinoba would have the answers. I have a feeling that this method leads to the stultification of the thinking of *Bhoodan* workers, they hesitate to initiate thought and there is a sense in the end that Vinoba has his workers on a string.

Vinoba often expresses himself in terms which seem to conflict. It is mainly because he speaks in relation to his listener and obviously can never cover the whole subject. For instance, this morning the question of China was raised by the Jan Sangh party man. He got a very straight answer according to his need which rather surprised me. What Vinoba said was that the need of the day was—the development of *Swarajya* in the villages, the overcoming of party, caste and other differences, and the army alert at the border. Then all efforts for peace through discussion should be made. It was unthinkable that there would be war, he said, because that would involve the whole world. It was his reference to the army which was surprising.

At the 2.30 p.m. meeting Vinoba was in his deep religious mood, speaking quietly as if from another world. He spoke about the Vishnu Sahasranam which he has recited each day for nearly a year. It is a recitation of the thousand names of God, but the interesting thing is that the name of Vishnu is only placed second. The first name is Vishwa

—which means the universe, so the greatest name is God incarnate in the universe—*Jai Jagat—Jai Bhagwan*—he said.

January 15th, 16th.

Hissar

This is the headquarters of the Hindi speaking area of the Punjab. The welcome was quite warm but there were not the masses that I have seen in the past. We had walked twelve miles on a slippery, wet road but *Baba* went straight to the platform to address the assembled crowd which must have numbered 2000. He spoke for forty minutes covering the whole challenge of the *Sarvodaya* Movement with great power. One notices, as such meetings, the tremendous affection with which people greet Vinoba as if he belongs to them, and this applies to the educated as well as to the uneducated. In fact, this becomes apparent as soon as he gets within a few miles of the city. First a doctor along with his whole family came in a car to greet him, then another doctor came on his cycle and walked along with us for the rest of the way. Teachers, businessmen, all who had some affection for the Saint Vinoba on the march, came out of the city to show their respect and affection. Each in their way may have contributed something in the movement and were thrilled at the opportunity to see face to face the initiator. The relationship can only be one of affection because what else has Vinoba been doing for nine years but try to spread the

Kingdom of Kindness—as he calls it—or to enliven in the community the spirit of love and sharing. No other public leader in the world can have had such personal affection shown towards him as Vinoba has, who else has walked amongst his people :

Vinoba is a power unto himself ! The evening prayer meeting was ready at 3 p.m. the crowd was smaller at first than in the morning; and when I arrived at 3.15 p.m. I was asked to speak, which I did in Hindi for fifteen minutes. Then *Baba* came. He was some minutes starting and when he did he spoke, as often he does, in a very low voice. Then the loud speaker seemed to fail and there was some disturbance. In spite of the attempts to explain on the part of the organisers, Vinoba sensed that something was wrong, felt disturbed and immediately announced the closure of the meeting with silent prayer. By that time there was a huge crowd, but perhaps the objective of most of them who came from a distance was fulfilled—they had seen Vinoba, the Saint and through that they would receive the blessing which no one else can give.

We were pestered right and left by students and it was impossible to do anything. Some were really interested, others just eager to try out their English, some were just cheeky.

On the following morning Vinoba had to be out at 4.30 a. m. as usual for a six mile walk. I went with him along with a party of twenty. We went to a Borstal Institu-

tion where there are youths too young to receive the penalty of the courts. It was really a gaol, though I was rather struck by the natural setting, huge gardens and playgrounds rather than armed guards. The inmates—smart young men from 18 to 20, were seated quietly. Vinoba was garlanded and led to a platform and there in his quiet way, not caring for anyone, he spoke for fifteen minutes. He spoke of Valmiki who, from being a thief and criminal, became the author of the Ramayan which is not only the story which converted him, but the story through which Valmiki has converted millions from wrong to right paths.

On the previous afternoon *Baba* had promised to speak at 8 a.m. the next morning, so instead of going to breakfast we went to the ground. The loud speaker was working but it was cold and rather early for most people and when I was with him walking to the platform I noticed no more than fifty people. Vinoba seemed to be happy, though, and said that he gave his best speeches to small groups. He sat behind the mike, collected himself for a few minutes, then began an address which lasted about one hour. By the time he had finished there were a few hundred present. It was a memorable occasion. *Baba* seemed conscious of it. At the outset he said that he did not know whether ever he would be in that area again so he would like to leave something with them, though it may not be what they expect. Then at the end he seemed to be filled with prophetic power and in that low confident

voice which he has on such occasions he said : "I am full of confidence. Whatever weakness may be visible in the movement, however weak are the six thousand odd workers throughout the country, I have with me a whole host of supporters from the past who have grown out of this soil. They live on and give help to all who are carrying out this mission." He had stopped two or three times to wipe tears from his eyes as he spoke of this soil of India which had given so much, and specially when he spoke of Pandit Malviya taking some of this soil to England with him when he went on one of his journeys. The address was really a recapitulation of cultural history and Indian's past in it. He spoke of how man first showed real humanity when he learned to befriend the cow and take its milk—no other species drinks the milk of another, he said. The greatest experiment in cultural history, Vinoba said, was Indian's experiment with vegetarianism, and in this, he said, the West was 5000 years behind India. He also gave the opinion that India's greatest contribution to the world was Satyagraha.

There was no evening meeting. At 6 o'clock I walked with Vinoba up and down the playfield along with the Deputy Commissioner. I like these intimate associations when one does not feel it necessary to ask questions. Just before that I had sat near him whilst he lay in his room in pain. His stomach ulcers were troubling him. He rubbed himself with his fingers and afterwards when all was well, he said: "these fingers are the best medicine."

IX

January 18th.

Eleven miles from Hissar. It is a real village with none of the signs of a marketing centre. Vinoba is staying in part of an incompletely built school, we are 100 yards away in a partly built house obviously belonging to a rich farmer. The floor is my bed. Why mention that, except that so often with Tibor who left at Hissar, we were given beds. A glass of milk, dates and a biscuit were served as breakfast. Swamy who has looked after us so much, hunted for a bathroom for me, but not even this modern house has been provided with one. He found one finally in the heart of the village—the only one in 150 houses—and when I got there and started using it, I found that there was no outlet in the room for the water so it spread through two other rooms ! Fortunately, the houses was not in use yet. It was in this village where I went round with a lady from Hissar who wanted to get *Sarvodaya Pastras* installed in every home. We mostly met the women in the houses with faces duly covered, and they were all ready to do what they were told. They took an earthen pot and got the youngest child of the family to place a handful of grain in it. I do not think many of them knew what they were doing but they were willing to do what they were told by this lady

who was well known to them. There is no doubt that they are very kindly, devout people, but terribly ignorant.

Again, when Vinoba arrived and started his morning address he sensed a disturbance and immediately said 'Jai Jagat' and went away.

It was here where a queer person seemed to appear from nowhere. He was noticed at the meeting wearing a badge with the words written on it in English—'World Guider'. Later he came and settled in our room and claimed that he was God and that wherever he is there is heaven. He was obviously a religious maniac, but when he was taken up in argument he would often laugh which helped a great deal. He would never give up the seriousness of his claim however.

January 19th. Uklana

This is the Railway Station from which I leave Baba again after twenty five days with him covering a distance of about 250 miles. It is good to be in pleasant surroundings, being housed in a large High School, though it seems to be worse than ever as regards crowds staring at and following me. The fact is that this generation of children have never seen an Englishman, yet they learn the English language and hear so much about the people. On arrival Vinoba spoke to the small crowd which was made up of teachers, students and village leaders. He spoke about Indian history, showing how the idea of ownership in land came to be in contradiction with India's cultural tradition.

Walking back to his room Vinoba promised to give me an Indian name, but although he spent some time reading for inspiration (as he said) he could not finally decide on one for me. He sent it later—‘*Lok Bandhu*’ !

—“Now I have visited every province in the country except Assam and every where I have said the same thing. Less than five acres of land is insufficient and any with less than that should be considered landless. But the land belongs to the Lord and those who have not enough land must be given it immediately for this is the age of love. We do international trade. This is based on love and understanding. The relationship between England and India is based on love. The tilling of the soil should be a united effort of the whole village.

Many do not understand my ideas, they think that *Gram Swarajya* would kill the peasantry. Prof. Ranga of the Swatantra Party thinks on these line. Two years ago I invited him to discuss the matter with me but unfortunately he did not come. Rajaji blessed me and appreciated my ideas of *Gram Swarajya*. Evidently, as it is a Swatantra Party, every person is entitled to have his own ideas.

The Yajurveda tells us that the earth is our mother, we cannot become its master yet today we have become masters over mother earth. In *Gram Swarajya* no one would buy and sell land, it would belong to the village.

This is not a new idea, we were having such practices in ancient times. In these days every village had *Gram Swarajya*, they used to call it *Panchayat Raj*. Without any

trace of centralisation the villagers were tied to each other as independent flowers. The custom of offering a garland is very ancient, offering a bouquet is foreign. The garland signifies the bond of affection. How Government is being run by the Goddess of power. In ancient days money was not used, everyone was given grains in exchange for his work. The British came and shattered this *Panchayat* structure, they thought that it was a State within a State. Village industries were destroyed, weavers and other craftsmen were driven out. Those who had no other way began to sell their land for cash for the first time. Lawyers and business men began to own land though they did not till it, and gradually as things had to be imported for use —cloth, spectacles etc. The purchase and sale of land became common.

Vinoba explained the difference between his conception of Government as against the normal democratic conception. The latter was like a bouquet of flowers tied tightly into one bunch. The finished product showed one mass of colour with no distinct flower visible. His and India's old conception was like a garland in which each flower was able to show forth its individual beauty and the thread which tied them together was the silken thread of love.

At the end of his address he said : "Donald is leaving today and I have spoken thus for him. I hope others have benefitted from it."

GLOSSARY OF NON-ENGLISH WORDS

Agnyatwas:—Literally means going underground. For some time Vinobaji decided to carry on his walking tour without fixing up a long drawn up programme so that he could concentrate his efforts any where for any number of days.

Bhoodan:—The land-gift movement.

Sarvodaya Paatra:—An earthen pitcher where the family is required to deposit daily a handful of grains or the smallest coin by the youngest member of the family to meet the expenditures of the Sarvodaya movement.

Padyatra:—Walking tour.

Gramdan:—A voluntary village community where all or at least a substantial majority of the villagers have given up individual ownership of land in favour of community ownership. The first gramdan was recorded in 1952 in the wake of the Bhoodan movement.

Jai Jagat:—The slogan coined by Vinobaji means Victory to the world. It shows his keenness of the necessity of rising above the national or political barriers.

Shanti-Sainik:—Member of peace-brigade.

Swamy:—Saint or holy person.

Baba:—*ibid*.

Sampattidan:—A programme of the Bhoodan movement, according to which the voluntary contributor is expected to spend a regular portion of his income towards the expenditures of some social service.

Vanprasthas:—The third stage of life according to Hindu view. A person is expected to retire from household affairs at this stage and prepare for himself for complete renunciation.

Sarvodaya:—The welfare of all—the philosophy of Mahatma Gandhi.

Rishi:—Sage

Nakad Dharma:—*Nakad* i.e., cash and *Dharma* means religion. The word suggests the practice of such a religious act that would fetch immediate benefit to the needy.

Udhar Dharma:—*Udhar* means credit. *Udhar Dharma* is just the reverse of the above practice.

Panchayat:—Indian form of direct democracy for the villages.

Upanishad:—Vedantic scriptures.

Sadhana:—Penance.

Ghee:—Clarified butter used as cooking medium.

Puri:—Pie fried in Ghee.

Yogis:—A class of mendicants, observing Yoga practices in seclusion.

Agni:—Fire.

Gram-Swaraj:—Self-sufficient village republic.

Shraddh Diwas:—Last rite of a Hindu generally observed after twelve days of death and repeated annually.

Jai Bhagawan:—God Almighty.

Satyagraha:—Non-violent resistance started by Gandhiji.

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